













Bald Eagle

Haliaeetus leucocephalus



Hope for our national symbol!

The bald eagle, our national symbol, is endangered in most states and threatened in a few others. A large population remains in Alaska. However, the number of bald eagles has increased dramatically in the last 25 years.



Did you know Arizona has the only population of desert-nesting bald eagles in the United States?

Many bald eagles seen in Arizona are winter visitors that return north in the spring. However, a small population (20 breeding pairs in 1989) build nests and remain here year round. These desert-nesting bald eagles live along the rivers and lakes in the Upper Sonoran desert.



Animal Facts

Habitat
Near lakes, seas, or rivers

Length
27-30 in. (68-76 cm);
wing span six to eight ft. (2-3m)

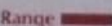
Nest
Inaccessible treetops or cliffs. Huge accumulation of sticks lined with pine needles and grasses

Eggs
Two, dull white

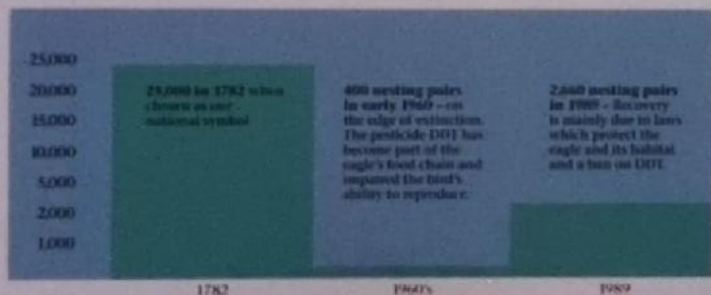
Incubation
35 days, by both sexes

Natural diet
Fish, water birds, and small to medium size mammals. Also carrion.

Zoo diet
Meat mixture and fish

Range 

Recovery from the edge of extinction. "Eagle population in the lower 48 states"



How to catch and hold a slippery fish.

Fish are the bald eagle's primary source of food. The eagle pierces the fish's body with its sharp talons. The grooves and bumps under the bald eagle's feet help grip the slippery meal.



Even shortening grooves and bumps

Can eagles see better than humans?



BIRDS OF PREY

What are raptors?

Raptors are birds of prey that hunt for their food. Their weapons are strong feet, sharp talons, and hooked beaks. Raptors include eagles, hawks, falcons, owls, and vultures.

A raptor uses its sharp, curved talons to grasp and kill prey. The strong, hooked beak then tears the flesh apart. The size and shape of the talons and beak vary according to the prey.



Bald eagle
preys on fish



Peregrine falcon
preys on birds



Barn owl
preys on mice

Birds of prey are beneficial in keeping rodent and insect populations under control.



Bald eagle

Discover other adaptations of birds of prey.

Rotate the wheel until the colored arrow points to the bird of your choice. Highlighted in the circles are an adaptation and its function.



Great horned owl



Red-tailed hawk



Kestrel



Peregrine falcon



Barn owl

Function

Prey is captured
by and crushed
with beak, tearing
apart energy

Adaptation



Long, curved
wings



Turkey vulture



Harris hawk



Screech owl